LESS THAN HUMAN

I WAS TRYING TO SAVE THE SAME HUMANITY
WHO UNIVERSALLY FORSOOK ME

An autobiographical and prophetic novel

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AUTHOR’S NOTE

This is an expanded autobiographical and prophetic literary manuscript based on the biographical information and documentary context supplied by the author. It does not invent private childhood scenes, conversations or motives. Where the narrative discusses records, it distinguishes the existence of a document from the truth of every statement contained in it. Allegations, interpretations and spiritual beliefs are presented as such.

The manuscript is a complete first narrative edition, not a claim to be a 100,000-word commercial novel or a substitute for a fully sourced documentary monograph. Further primary-source verification and additional remembered life history can deepen later editions.

The author’s central principles are: PRESERVATION FIRST. EXAMINATION SECOND. CONCLUSION LAST. THE RECORD STAYS FREE. FAITH IS NOT A FINDING.

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PROLOGUE

THE HUMANITY I WAS TRYING TO SAVE

There is a sentence at the centre of this book: I was trying to save the same humanity who universally forsook me. It is not a statistical claim about every person who has ever lived. It is the language of a life that came to feel abandoned by the very human community to which it had repeatedly tried to contribute. It is an emotional truth, a literary proposition and a question addressed to the reader. What happens when a person spends years insisting that other people must be treated as human, and then experiences systems and relationships in which he struggles to receive that same recognition?

I write from inside that question. I do not write as a detached observer who has never been touched by the events being described. I am the person whose life is at the centre of the account. I am Richard William McLean, publicly known as Dr Barran Dodger. The names, the books, the research, the archive and the public declarations belong to one continuing life. They are not costumes worn by separate people. They are forms through which I have attempted to make experience visible.

This book is autobiographical, but it is also a novel in the sense that it gives a shaped literary form to a life whose meaning cannot be contained in a list of dates. It is prophetic in the sense that it carries a spiritual and moral vision: that human beings will eventually have to confront what they have done, what they have permitted, what they have ignored and what they have preserved. The prophetic voice is my own expression of belief and interpretation. It does not turn every allegation into an established fact, nor does it ask the reader to surrender judgement. It asks the reader to remain present long enough to examine the record and the human being behind it.

I will not invent childhood scenes to create an easy beginning. I will not manufacture conversations, attribute private motives to people without evidence, or transform an unresolved administrative event into a proven conspiracy. The discipline of this book is part of its meaning. Where I remember, I will speak from memory. Where a document records something, I will identify it as a record. Where I make an allegation, I will say so. Where I interpret, I will own the interpretation. Where I believe, I will not disguise belief as a court finding.

The story begins before the files. It moves through art, journalism, advocacy, education, research, institutional encounters, documentary preservation and the construction of a public archive. It reaches the present without pretending that every question has been answered. The archive is not the whole life. It is what grew around a life when the ordinary ways of being heard seemed insufficient.

I want the reader to meet the person before being asked to assess the claims. I want the reader to understand the work before being asked to understand the conflict. I want the reader to see that a person can be intellectually serious, creatively ambitious, wounded, angry, spiritually searching and imperfect at the same time. Humanity is not a prize awarded only to people who are easy to understand.

The record stays free. Faith is not a finding. Preservation comes first, examination second, conclusion last. Those principles are not a retreat from conviction. They are the conditions under which conviction can remain honest.

This is the story of a life that kept trying to speak. It is also a question about the people and institutions that decide whether they will listen.

BOOK ONE — BEFORE THEY KNEW MY NAME

BEFORE THE WORLD MADE ME A CASE

CHAPTER TWO

LEARNING TO SEE

My first enduring language was visual. Before a person can explain every idea in a sentence, there is the possibility of seeing: noticing shape, proportion, contrast, balance, omission and emphasis. An image can communicate before its maker has found the words to explain why it matters. It can also conceal. What is placed in the frame becomes visible; what is left outside it may disappear from the viewer's understanding.

That tension would become important throughout my life. The artist learns that presentation is never entirely neutral. A crop changes meaning. A headline directs attention. A sequence creates an argument. A document can be accurate in its individual sentences and still mislead through what it excludes. I would later encounter these questions in journalism, advocacy, academic work and the examination of government records. The underlying problem remained recognisable: who controls the frame, and what happens to the person or event outside it?

I do not claim that every later interest was already present in my early artistic development. It is tempting to make the past look more orderly than it was. What I can say is that the practice of working with images gave me a durable respect for detail and for the difference between appearance and meaning. Looking carefully is not the same as knowing everything. It is the beginning of responsible interpretation.

Art also offered a way to make something that could exist beyond the moment of its creation. A drawing, design or visual composition can be revisited. It can be examined by another person. It can be misunderstood, appreciated, criticised or ignored. Once made, it has a life beyond the intention of its maker. That is both the vulnerability and the power of creative work.

The work of an artist is not simply to decorate the world. It can organise attention. It can give form to a question. It can make an invisible relationship visible, or reveal how a familiar arrangement has been constructed. The artist is not automatically right about what the image means. The viewer brings a history of their own. Meaning is made in the encounter between the work, its context and the person looking at it.

In later years, I would return repeatedly to the problem of witnessing. What does it mean to observe something? What does it mean to preserve what one has seen? How can a person distinguish an event from an interpretation of that event? How can an image or document be kept available so that another person can examine it independently? These questions connect my creative work to my documentary work, even though the methods are different.

The discipline of seeing also requires humility. An image never contains the whole world. A photograph has a point of view. A graphic has a hierarchy. A record has a purpose and a boundary. The fact that something is visible does not make it complete; the fact that something is absent does not prove why it is absent. To look carefully is to recognise both what can be seen and what cannot yet be established.

That is one of the principles I want this book to carry. I will not ask the reader to mistake intensity for proof. I will not ask the reader to mistake official language for the whole truth. I will ask that the material be examined in context, with the same care that a responsible artist gives to the composition and the same care that a responsible researcher gives to a source.

CHAPTER THREE

THE NEWSPAPER YEARS

I worked as a newspaper and news graphics artist, including work associated with the Herald Sun and The Age. Those years belong to the professional history from which I understand the relationship between information, presentation and public attention. News graphics are not incidental ornaments attached to journalism. At their best, they help readers understand complicated material. They can make scale, sequence, geography, comparison and consequence easier to grasp.

The work requires more than visual skill. It requires an understanding of the story being communicated, the accuracy of the information, the constraints of space and time, and the responsibility that comes with turning data or events into a public image. A graphic can clarify. It can also oversimplify. A misleading scale or an unexamined assumption can distort the reader's understanding as surely as a misleading sentence.

I have described myself as having been paid and recognised in a journalistic working context. The precise employment history, dates, duties and status should be established through the relevant records wherever a formal account requires them. The lived significance of the work, however, is not limited to a job title. It was part of my development as a communicator and as a person interested in how institutions and public narratives shape what people believe.

The newspaper environment places a person inside a collective process. Information passes through reporters, editors, designers, production staff and publication systems. Each stage has its own pressures. The final page appears coherent, but the work behind it is distributed. The reader sees the finished composition, not every decision that produced it.

That experience gave me a practical understanding of how public meaning is assembled. It also left me alert to the power of institutional framing. A person can become the subject of a story without controlling the language used to describe them. A complex experience can be compressed into a label. A dispute can be presented as a personality conflict. A human being can disappear behind the categories through which others have decided to understand him.

My relationship with The Age later became associated, in my account, with the publication and aftermath of my autobiography, Recovered, Not Cured. I have also described experiences of public humiliation connected with the Herald Sun. Those are important parts of my testimony, but a careful edition should distinguish my recollection and interpretation from independently established employment decisions, editorial records or the intentions of individuals. I do not need to invent motives to explain that an experience can leave a profound mark.

The newspaper years taught me that the public record is powerful, but not complete. A published page may survive while the conversations and circumstances surrounding it disappear. A headline may be remembered long after the qualifications in the body of the article have been forgotten. The same is true of administrative records. The document survives; the human context may not.

I would later become both a maker of public information and a person trying to correct the public description of his own life. That reversal is one of the central tensions of this story. I knew something about the craft of framing. I knew how a visual hierarchy directs the eye. Yet I would find myself in circumstances where I felt that other people controlled the frame, and where my attempts to supply context seemed to generate still more paperwork.

The lesson I carry is not that every institution is dishonest or every public account is false. It is that the frame must be examined. Who made it? For what purpose? What evidence did it include? What did it leave out? And can the person represented within it respond? Those questions would follow me from the newsroom into the archive.

CHAPTER FOUR

RECOVERED, NOT CURED

The title Recovered, Not Cured became one of the defining expressions of my public work. Published in 2002, it placed a distinction at the centre of the conversation: recovery and cure are not identical ideas. A person may rebuild a life without being returned to some imagined state of perfect health. A person may develop skills, relationships, purpose and agency while continuing to live with difficulty. The language of recovery can open possibilities, but it can also become another standard against which people are judged.

I wrote from the conviction that people who experience mental distress deserve to be heard as human beings, not reduced to diagnostic descriptions. Their accounts should not be dismissed simply because they have received a psychiatric label or encountered a mental health service. Equally, a person's account should be treated with care and examined in context, as any serious testimony should be. The point is not to replace one unquestioned authority with another. The point is to restore the person as a participant in decisions about their own life.

Over many years I became involved in mental-health advocacy, including work with people experiencing mental illness and with carers. My preferred description of this history is approximately thirty years of advocacy. I have also described work in roles including arts therapy, life coaching, support work and as a registered NDIS provider. The exact dates, registration periods and formal scope of each role should be confirmed against certificates, provider records and employment documents when a fully sourced biography is prepared.

Advocacy is often described as though it were a simple act of speaking on behalf of someone else. In practice, it can mean listening when a person has been repeatedly interrupted, helping someone articulate a concern, challenging a decision, explaining a process or insisting that a person's preferences matter. It can also mean accepting that the advocate does not own another person's story. The person receiving support remains the central authority on their own experience, subject to the ordinary responsibilities of evidence, safety and shared decision-making.

My work and writing addressed psychiatric drugs, harm reduction and the argument that questions of drug policy should be considered as health issues. These subjects are complicated. They involve evidence, lived experience, medical practice, law, social policy and competing ideas about risk. I have spoken and written in national and international forums about these questions. The position I developed was not that every treatment is harmful or that every individual should make the same choice. It was that people need honest information, meaningful consent, careful monitoring and respect for their rights.

The public conversation about mental health can become trapped between two forms of simplification. One presents professional authority as sufficient in itself. The other assumes that personal experience automatically settles every clinical or policy question. Neither is adequate. Lived experience is evidence of what a person has experienced; it is not a substitute for every kind of research. Professional expertise can be valuable; it does not erase the obligation to listen or the possibility of error.

The title Recovered, Not Cured also carries a wider meaning for me. It challenges the idea that a human being must become uncomplicated before being allowed a full life. People are not machines waiting for a technician to restore them to factory settings. They have histories, contradictions, ambitions and relationships. They can be vulnerable and capable. They can need support and still possess authority over their own lives.

When I later found myself the subject of institutional processes, I would return to the same principle. A person should not be reduced to the file that describes them. A person’s history of service contact should not become a universal explanation for everything they say. The task is to examine each claim, each decision and each piece of evidence on its own terms, while never losing sight of the person who is living through the consequences.

CHAPTER FIVE

THE ADVOCATE'S CONTRADICTION

There is a contradiction at the heart of advocacy. The advocate argues that people must be heard, yet the advocate can discover that his own voice is difficult to place within the systems he has spent years trying to influence. He may know the language of rights and service standards, but knowledge does not guarantee that a complaint will be resolved. He may understand how to prepare a submission, but that does not mean the institution receiving it will agree with his interpretation.

I came to understand advocacy as work that often takes place between the promise of a system and the experience of the person required to use it. Policies speak in general terms. People live in particular circumstances. A policy may describe a pathway, but the individual still has to find the right form, the correct contact, the relevant deadline and the person authorised to make a decision. For someone under pressure, the distance between a formal entitlement and practical access can become enormous.

I have always wanted advocacy to mean more than complaint. It should be a practice of making conditions better, improving information, identifying avoidable harm and strengthening the capacity of people to participate in decisions. It should also be willing to scrutinise its own assumptions. An advocate can be mistaken. A service can be helpful in one respect and inadequate in another. A person can have legitimate concerns without every interpretation of an event being established.

That complexity is not weakness. It is the material from which credible advocacy is made. If I ask institutions to distinguish evidence from assumption, I must apply the same discipline to my own account. If I ask them to read documents in context, I must preserve the context of documents I publish. If I ask for procedural fairness, I must not present an unresolved process as though it had already produced a final finding.

The contradiction became more painful when I felt that the language I had used to defend others was not available to me in the same way. I experienced the difference between being a person who can explain a system from the outside and a person whose daily life is affected by its decisions. A form is no longer an abstract administrative object when access to money, accommodation, support or medical care depends upon the process surrounding it.

I do not claim that every difficulty I encountered had one cause. The institutional landscape is fragmented. Different agencies have different powers, records and responsibilities. A delay may arise from a missing document, an unclear request, a jurisdictional boundary, a resource constraint or a decision that someone has made. The reason must be established rather than assumed. But fragmentation itself can have a human effect. The person seeking help may be required to carry

information from one office to another, repeating the story while each part of the system sees only its own section.

This is where the advocate's contradiction becomes a moral question. If a person who knows the language of rights can still struggle to obtain an answer, what happens to someone who has less time, less confidence, less literacy, fewer resources or no stable support? The answer cannot be that the person should simply become better at navigating the maze. Institutions exist partly because individuals cannot reasonably be expected to solve every structural problem alone.

I wanted to help make systems more humane. I would later become deeply occupied with records of my own encounters with them. The transition was not a clean one. It involved frustration, determination, exhaustion and the repeated attempt to make a complicated history intelligible. The work of advocacy had taught me that a person should not be abandoned because their circumstances are difficult. I would have to insist on that principle when the person needing recognition was me.

CHAPTER SIX

THE ACADEMIC QUESTION

Education gave me another way to investigate the world. I completed a Master of Arts in Education and later undertook doctoral research at Victoria University. My PhD, awarded in 2020, concerned the ethics of artificial intelligence and posthumanism, global catastrophic risks and the end-stage Anthropocene, alongside the ethical opinions of young people. These subjects may appear distant from the immediate concerns of a person trying to navigate institutions, but they share a central question: what responsibilities do human beings have when the systems they create begin to shape the conditions of life?

Artificial intelligence is often discussed through the language of capability. What can a system calculate? How quickly can it process information? What tasks can it automate? Those questions matter, but they are incomplete. We must also ask who benefits, who carries the risk, who can challenge an outcome and who remains visible when a decision is converted into data. The ethics of technology is not merely a technical matter. It is a question about power, responsibility and the distribution of consequences.

Posthumanism complicates the assumption that humanity is a fixed and self-contained category. It asks us to reconsider the boundaries between human beings, technologies, environments and other forms of life. The Anthropocene places human activity within a planetary context. Global catastrophic risks remind us that decisions made in one place can have consequences far beyond the people who make them. These questions demand intellectual seriousness, but they also demand moral imagination.

I was interested in the ethical opinions of young people because they are not simply future citizens waiting to inherit decisions made by adults. They already have perspectives on the world they are entering. Their views can reveal assumptions that established institutions have stopped questioning. Listening to young people is not a symbolic gesture. It is part of taking seriously the people who will live with the consequences of current choices.

Academic research requires a different discipline from personal testimony. It requires a question, a method, engagement with relevant scholarship, careful interpretation and a willingness to identify limitations. A doctorate does not make a person infallible. It demonstrates that a particular body of research has met the requirements of an academic process. The qualification is meaningful, but it does not settle every later dispute in the holder’s life.

I have sometimes found that formal credentials and lived experience are treated as though they must compete. They should not. Academic knowledge can illuminate a problem, while lived

experience can reveal dimensions that abstract models miss. Neither should be used to silence the other. The task is to understand what each form of knowledge can establish and where its limits lie.

The questions I studied would later return in a more immediate form. Administrative systems increasingly depend on databases, records, classifications and digital interfaces. A person's identity can be represented through a series of fields. A decision can be made through a process that is difficult for the affected person to inspect. The same ethical questions arise: what is the quality of the information? Can the person correct it? Is the process explainable? Who is accountable when the result causes harm?

The academic chapter of my life did not provide a shield against difficulty. It gave me tools for asking better questions. It taught me to distinguish a proposition from its evidence, a method from its conclusion and an argument from the authority of the person making it. Those disciplines became essential when I began to examine the documentary history of my own life.

BOOK TWO — WHEN THE SUBJECT BECAME THE CASE

THE MOMENT THE FILE TOOK OVER

CHAPTER EIGHT

THE WHISTLEBLOWER'S RECORD

The language of whistleblowing carries both promise and uncertainty. It suggests that a person has raised concerns about wrongdoing or risk, but the legal and administrative treatment of a disclosure depends on the applicable legislation, the receiving body, the content of the information and the decision made under the relevant process. A person may believe they have made a public-interest disclosure. An agency may assess whether the material meets a statutory definition. Those are related questions, but they are not identical.

My documentary history includes public-interest disclosure material and correspondence with oversight bodies. One important item is a Federal Court-related public-interest disclosure assessment dated 27 March 2023, as identified in the archive. The existence and precise character of that assessment must be distinguished from a Federal Court judgment. Unless the original document establishes that a court made a judicial determination, it should not be described as a court finding. The title of a file is not enough to establish the legal nature of its contents.

The archive also identifies a notice dated 9 May 2023 concerning a decision not to allocate a disclosure, reference E23-107719, as well as a request for consent to provide details and a separate notice dated 18 June 2023. It identifies a later notice dated 24 March 2024, reference E24-136152. These are procedural records. Their wording, statutory basis, dates and relationship to each other must be checked against the original documents before a final legal chronology is published.

A decision not to allocate a disclosure is not the same thing as a finding that the disclosure is false. Nor is it a finding that the alleged conduct occurred. It is a procedural outcome that must be understood through the law and reasons applicable to that decision. The distinction matters because a public archive should not transform administrative language into a stronger conclusion than the source supports.

I have also identified correspondence with the National Anti-Corruption Commission, parliamentarians, the Australian Human Rights Commission and other bodies. The archive records that statements and contacts were made. The fact that a statement was sent establishes the act of making it, not every factual proposition contained within it. Acknowledgement of correspondence establishes receipt or processing, not necessarily agreement with the sender’s account. These distinctions are not technical evasions. They are the basis of a reliable record.

There is a particular loneliness in making a disclosure and then having to document what happened to the disclosure itself. The original concern becomes one file. The agency response becomes another. A request for further information becomes another. A decision about allocation

becomes another. The person who began by trying to raise a concern may find himself managing a second history: the history of the system's response to the first history.

I cannot ask the reader to infer a single hidden plan from every procedural step. I can ask the reader to examine the sequence, the language, the dates, the statutory explanations and the practical consequences. If a pattern is supported, it should be described. If there are gaps, they should remain visible. If a contradiction appears between an index and an original document, it must be investigated rather than silently corrected.

The whistleblower's record is therefore not a simple tale of vindication or defeat. It is a record of concerns raised, processes engaged, responses received and questions that remain. My conviction that the concerns deserve examination is part of my testimony. The documentary task is to make that examination possible. I will not pretend that the archive has already supplied every answer. I will not permit the absence of a final answer to erase the fact that the questions were raised.

To preserve a disclosure is to preserve the possibility of scrutiny. It is not to predetermine the result of that scrutiny.

CHAPTER NINE

THE HUMAN BEING INSIDE THE SYSTEM

The administrative record can make a person appear endlessly available for assessment and yet difficult to reach as a human being. The person is asked for information, asked to clarify, asked to provide documents, asked to wait, asked to repeat, asked to respond. Each request may be reasonable in isolation. The cumulative burden can become unreasonable when the person has to carry the entire process without adequate support.

Disability services and support systems are intended to assist people to live with greater choice, independence and participation. The principles are important. Their practical value depends on how they are implemented. A plan is not the same as a service delivered. An approval is not the same as a safe and reliable arrangement. A provider's existence does not prove that the support required on a particular day was supplied. These matters need records: agreements, rosters, case notes, communications, incident reports and the person's own account.

My later experiences in supported accommodation and disability support became another part of the documentary history. I have raised concerns about support, communication, attendance and safeguarding. Those concerns should be examined against the relevant agreements, service records, policies and responses. I do not need to state that every person involved acted with a particular motive in order to insist that the practical questions be answered. What support was agreed? What was delivered? What was missed? What was recorded? What action followed?

The human consequences of service failures are not abstract. Support can affect whether a person can attend an appointment, obtain food, manage medication, communicate with others, care for an animal or maintain a stable routine. When a person depends on several organisations, the boundaries between their responsibilities can become a source of confusion. The person may be told to contact another worker, another office or another service. Each referral may make administrative sense while leaving the immediate need unresolved.

Money is also a form of access. A person may have funds recorded in an account and still be unable to use them because a card, application, verification process or account restriction prevents access. The distinction between having money and being able to reach it is fundamental. A person who cannot pay for food, transport, phone credit or medicine experiences the restriction in practical terms, not as a balance on a screen.

When I have described difficulties obtaining access to my own money, I have wanted the immediate problem addressed: identify the restriction, explain the reason, provide a safe way to verify identity and restore access where appropriate. It is understandable that a person under severe

pressure may interpret repeated barriers as deliberate. But the way to establish the cause is to obtain the bank's explanation, preserve communications and examine the transaction and account records. The urgency of the need does not require an unsupported conclusion about motive.

The same principle applies to accommodation and support. A person's complaint should not be dismissed because it is strongly expressed. Anger may be the language of accumulated frustration. At the same time, the strongest complaint is one that identifies dates, events, requests, responses and consequences. A clear record makes it harder for an organisation to answer only the emotion while avoiding the substance.

I have wanted to be treated as a person capable of making decisions, expressing preferences and identifying problems. Needing support does not cancel agency. Having a disability does not remove the right to be heard. Having a complex history does not make every new concern an extension of that history. Each event deserves to be considered on its own evidence.

This is the human being inside the system: not a perfect witness, not a permanent patient, not a case number, but a person who needs ordinary things and has the right to ask for them. The moral test of a service is not the elegance of its policy statement. It is what happens when a person actually needs the service.

CHAPTER TEN

THE ARCHIVE AS AN ACT OF SURVIVAL

The archive grew because I wanted the documentary history to remain accessible. I did not want important records to be scattered across inboxes, devices, folders and disconnected websites. I wanted a reader to be able to follow a chronology, locate a source and examine the original material. The archive became a practical response to the difficulty of keeping a long and fragmented history intelligible.

It contains official correspondence, administrative documents, submissions, personal statements, research, creative writing and other material. Its scale has changed across different snapshots and inventories. Counts reported at different times are not interchangeable. A preservation copy, a repository file count, a PDF index and a blockchain-authentication count measure different things. A reliable description must identify the date of the inventory, the method used and the category being counted.

The archive's purpose is not to make every file equally authoritative. A government letter and a personal reflection are different kinds of sources. A statutory decision and an email acknowledging receipt have different functions. A statement made by me is evidence that I made that statement; it is not automatically independent corroboration of every fact described. A creative or prophetic text is evidence of my writing and belief, not a substitute for a legal determination.

This is why cataloguing matters. A useful archive needs titles, dates, source descriptions, stable links, document identifiers where available and a way to distinguish original records from later copies or derivative indexes. It needs to preserve uncertainty rather than hide it. If two documents appear to have conflicting dates, the conflict should be recorded and investigated. If a file appears twice, the archive should establish whether the copies are identical, revised or merely differently named.

Digital preservation also introduces technical questions. A file can be altered without its visible title changing. A link can break. A repository can be reorganised. A PDF can contain text that is difficult to search. A checksum can help establish whether a file has changed since a particular hash was generated, but it does not prove that the original file was authentic when first obtained. Blockchain records can preserve a timestamped commitment to data, but they do not independently establish the truth of the document's contents.

These qualifications do not diminish the value of preservation. They explain what preservation can and cannot do. A reliable archive should make it easier for someone else to inspect the material,

not ask them to accept the archive owner's conclusions without examination. It should provide the route back to the source wherever possible.

I have used public repositories and websites to make parts of the archive available. The main archive, the rebuild, the Official Government Documents Register and the related publishing and church sites are different parts of a larger body of work. They have different purposes. The archive preserves and organises documentary material. The register provides a structured way to locate official documents. The creative sites present books, gospels, essays and prophetic writing. The publishing house explores a separate model for distributing literary work while keeping the documentary record freely accessible.

The archive is also an act of authorship. To decide what to preserve, how to describe it and how to place it in sequence is to make choices about meaning. That responsibility must be acknowledged. I cannot claim that a catalogue is neutral simply because it is technical. The safeguard is transparency: explain the method, identify the source, disclose uncertainty and allow readers to reach their own conclusions.

At times, the work of preservation has felt like the only reliable way to keep the story from dissolving. A document can be copied. A link can be repaired. An index can be rebuilt. A chronology can be corrected. These are modest actions, but they create continuity. They allow a future reader to encounter material that might otherwise have become inaccessible.

The archive is not my life. It is not my identity. It is not a substitute for justice, care, friendship or ordinary human contact. It is a structure I built around a record because I believed the record mattered. Its deepest purpose is to return the material to public examination, not to imprison me inside it.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE GOSPELS AND THE WITNESS

Alongside the documentary archive, I developed a body of spiritual and prophetic writing. These works include the Gospel of the Love Chain, the Gospel of Barran Dodger, the Gospel of the Witness Barran Dodger, the Prophecy of the Witness and related texts. Their language is different from the language of administrative records. They operate through symbol, declaration, moral argument and spiritual imagination.

I do not want the reader to confuse these forms. A prophetic text can express a person's deepest understanding of an experience without becoming an official finding about the actions of another person. A spiritual interpretation can be central to the author's life without being presented as independently verifiable fact. The distinction allows the writing to retain its force while remaining honest about what kind of claim it makes.

The figure of the witness has become important to my understanding of myself. A witness observes, remembers and speaks. A witness may be believed, doubted, misunderstood or ignored. The word also carries a moral responsibility: to say what one knows, to distinguish what one has seen from what one has inferred, and to resist the temptation to fill gaps with certainty simply because uncertainty is painful.

The witness is not necessarily a person who has all the answers. Sometimes the witness is the person who refuses to let a question disappear. Sometimes the task is to preserve a letter, a date, a recording, a decision or a memory until someone has the opportunity to examine it. The witness does not control the final judgement. He can contribute to the conditions under which judgement becomes possible.

My spiritual language has often taken the form of return, light, preservation, reckoning and the refusal of erasure. These are images through which I interpret survival and moral responsibility. They are not a demand that the reader adopt my beliefs. The reader may approach them as theology, poetry, autobiographical symbolism or a form of literary prophecy. What matters is that their place in my life is represented accurately.

The spiritual dimension also complicates the idea of victory. I have written about vindication, but vindication need not mean that every institution will agree with me or that every unresolved matter will end in the way I desire. It can also mean refusing to abandon the value of one's own humanity while waiting for a process to reach its conclusion. It can mean preserving the ability to speak without allowing the struggle to consume every other part of life.

There is a danger in turning suffering into a sacred identity. If the witness exists only because he has been wounded, then healing can begin to feel like a threat to the story. I do not want that. The purpose of the witness is not to remain permanently injured. It is to make truth, memory and moral attention possible. A life must be larger than the account of what hurt it.

The gospels and prophetic texts are part of my creative world. They express my search for meaning, my spiritual convictions and my response to experiences I have found difficult to explain. Their place in this novel is not to replace documentary examination, but to reveal the interior life that a register cannot contain. The archive can show what was received, sent or decided. It cannot, by itself, show what it felt like to keep going.

The witness remains because the human being remains. That is the claim I want the reader to encounter beneath the symbolic language.

CHAPTER TWELVE

THE PUBLIC IDENTITY

A public identity is built through repetition. A name appears on a book, a website, a research paper, a public statement or a social post. Over time, readers begin to associate the name with a particular body of work. The identity becomes recognisable. It can gather meaning, but it can also become a container into which other people place assumptions.

Dr Barran Dodger became the public identity through which I published and organised much of my later work. The name carries a literary and symbolic quality. It allows the work to speak in a register that is not identical to the formal language of Richard William McLean's official records. The two remain connected. The public identity does not erase the person, and the formal identity does not exhaust the creative life.

The internet made it possible to publish without waiting for a traditional gatekeeper. It also created a different set of responsibilities. A website can be changed quickly, but readers may rely on a page long after it has been revised. A link may be copied elsewhere. A statement may circulate without its context. A public archive can reach people across borders, but it can also expose personal information or create confusion if its structure is unclear.

I have wanted the work to be accessible. I have also wanted the archive to remain free. The publishing house is a separate creative and commercial idea: a way to distribute books and literary work without placing the documentary record behind a paywall. The distinction matters. Public access to evidence and the sale of creative editions are not contradictory when the boundaries are clearly explained.

The public identity has also required me to consider how I describe myself. Titles and qualifications should be accurate. Professional roles should be described in ways supported by records. Awards and institutional associations should be named precisely. A documentary association with a collection or centre should not be inflated into an endorsement of every later claim. A PhD should be described by its actual award and subject, not as proof of unrelated propositions.

This discipline is not a concession to people who might wish to diminish the work. It is a way of protecting the work from avoidable error. A biography that is precise is more durable than one that attempts to make every line sound triumphant. The strongest public identity is one that can withstand examination.

The name Dr Barran Dodger has become associated with a large and varied body of writing: autobiographical, academic, political, spiritual, creative and documentary. The work does not always

speak in one voice. That is part of its history. A person can write a research paper in one register and a prophetic declaration in another. The reader should be told which kind of text they are encountering and how it should be interpreted.

The public identity can create a sense of continuity during periods when ordinary life feels fragmented. A book can be finished. A page can be published. A catalogue can be updated. These acts give form to time. But a public identity can also become demanding. It can make a person feel obliged to respond to every criticism, correct every misunderstanding and maintain a constant presence. No person can live entirely as their own public archive.

I want to be able to put the work down and still remain myself. I want to be able to write without turning every experience into evidence. I want the public identity to serve the human being, not the human being to become a servant of the identity. That distinction will matter more as the story moves towards its present tense.

BOOK THREE — THE WITNESS REMAINS

THE COST OF CONTINUING

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

THE PARADOX OF SURVIVAL

Survival is often narrated as a victory that becomes obvious in retrospect. The survivor stands at the end of the story, looks back and explains how every obstacle made them stronger. Real survival is less polished. It may involve repetition, exhaustion, uncertainty and days when the next step is not clear. It may also involve ordinary pleasures and moments of relief that do not fit the public story.

I have written about the paradox of survival because the act of continuing can become both a source of strength and a burden. The person who has learned to document everything may find it difficult to stop documenting. The person who has learned to defend his account may begin to experience every disagreement as a threat. The person who has built a public identity around testimony may struggle to find a private space in which he is not required to explain himself.

There is a difference between remembering and reliving. Remembering can create understanding. Reliving can trap the present inside the past. The work of writing should help establish a relationship with experience, not make every day a repetition of the worst day. I cannot promise that a book will resolve what remains unresolved. I can hope that shaping the story will create enough distance for thought, and enough continuity for the reader to understand how one chapter led to another.

Survival also requires the recognition of needs that are not intellectual. A person needs rest. A person needs companionship, food, shelter, health care, communication and safety. These needs do not become less important because the person has written a PhD thesis or assembled a large archive. Nor does the existence of a public mission mean that every practical difficulty must be interpreted as part of that mission.

The ordinary is not a distraction from the extraordinary. It is where life happens. A meal, a conversation, a walk, a reliable appointment, a safe place to sleep or the ability to care for a companion animal can restore a measure of agency. These things may not look significant in a public chronology, but they are often the conditions that make any larger work possible.

I have wanted to preserve a record of what I believe happened, but I also want to preserve the possibility of a future that is not wholly governed by that record. The past deserves examination. The future deserves room. A person should not have to choose between telling the truth about hardship and allowing himself the possibility of happiness.

The paradox is that the archive exists because I did not want the story erased, while the act of living requires that I not become identical with the archive. I can be its author and still be more than its subject. I can be the witness and still be a person who needs ordinary care. I can write about

injustice and still recognise kindness when it appears. I can remain critical without making suspicion the only way I encounter the world.

Survival is not proof that everything was justified. It is not evidence that every allegation is true. It is not a reason to romanticise suffering. It is the fact that a life continued, and the decision to make something meaningful from the time that remains.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

LESS THAN HUMAN

The title of this book is deliberately severe. Less Than Human describes the experience of being treated, or feeling treated, as though one's full humanity has become secondary to a category, a file, a process or an institutional convenience. It names a moral wound. It does not mean that I believe I am less human. It means that I have struggled with circumstances in which recognition seemed conditional, delayed or withheld.

The subtitle is equally uncompromising: I Was Trying to Save the Same Humanity Who Universally Forsook Me. It expresses the contradiction I have lived with. I spent years advocating for people who needed recognition, dignity and a fair hearing. I wrote about the responsibilities of systems and the obligations people have to one another. Later, I experienced a profound sense of abandonment. The word universally is the language of that emotional experience, not a literal claim that every person in the world rejected me. The sentence is an indictment of the gap between humanity's stated values and the way a vulnerable person can experience its institutions.

The question is not whether I have always been right. No human being is always right. The question is whether a person's mistakes, intensity, vulnerability or disputed interpretations justify the loss of ordinary dignity. They do not. A person can be challenged without being humiliated. A claim can be rejected with reasons. A decision can be reviewed. A complaint can be investigated. A person can be offered support without having their agency erased.

The same standard applies to me. If I make an error, it should be identified. If a date is wrong, it should be corrected. If a document does not establish what I thought it established, the archive should say so. If a conclusion remains unresolved, it should remain unresolved. I do not lose my humanity by being corrected. Nor should another person lose theirs because I am angry or disappointed with them.

The moral test is whether we can maintain human recognition while disagreeing about facts, responsibility and interpretation. That is difficult. It requires patience, clear language and an acceptance that the other person is not reducible to the role they occupy in our story. It requires institutions to respond to the substance of concerns and individuals to avoid turning suspicion into certainty without evidence.

I have described experiences that I interpret as targeting, betrayal and coordinated harm. Those allegations must be assessed through specific evidence and competent processes. This novel does not declare them proven merely by placing them in a compelling narrative. It records that they form part

of my testimony and the meaning I have made of events. The reader should be able to distinguish the documentary record from my interpretation and my spiritual understanding.

But there is something that does not depend on proving every disputed proposition: the need for humane treatment. A person does not have to establish a conspiracy before they deserve access to money, a safe place to live, clear communication, appropriate support and an answer to a complaint. Human dignity is not conditional on winning an argument.

I return to the beginning. Before the world made me a case, I was a human being. I remain one now. The books, the doctorate, the public name, the archive and the declarations are parts of my life, but they are not the price of my humanity. I do not need to produce another document to qualify for recognition. I do not need to turn every private moment into evidence. I do not need to be understood in every respect before I can be treated with respect.

Less than human is the condition I am writing against. The book’s title is not my final definition of myself. It is the name of the question I am putting to the world.

EPILOGUE

THE RECORD STAYS FREE

I began with a person before the record. I end with a person who has made a record, and who must now find a way to live beyond it.

The archive remains available as a body of material for examination. Its contents should be read according to their source, date, purpose and evidentiary status. Official records should be distinguished from personal testimony. Allegations should be identified as allegations. Interpretations should be owned as interpretations. Spiritual beliefs should be represented honestly as beliefs. Unresolved matters should not be given artificial endings.

That discipline is not a weakening of the story. It is what allows the story to remain open to scrutiny. Preservation first. Examination second. Conclusion last. The record stays free. Faith is not a finding.

I have written as an artist who learned to look, as a newspaper graphics worker who learned something about public framing, as an advocate who argued for dignity, as an academic who studied ethical responsibility, as a writer who developed a public identity and as a person who became responsible for preserving a complicated documentary history. None of these roles cancels the others. None of them tells the whole story.

I do not know how every unresolved matter will end. I do not know which questions will receive a satisfactory answer, which documents will be found, which decisions will be reviewed or which interpretations will change with further evidence. I cannot promise the reader a neat resolution where life has not provided one. A false ending would be another form of distortion.

What I can offer is a beginning, a sequence of chapters and a method of reading. I can offer the distinction between the human being and the file. I can offer the work that has been made, the records that have been preserved and the questions that remain. I can offer my testimony without demanding that it be mistaken for a final determination.

The witness is not the archive. The witness is the person who remains capable of speaking, listening, revising and living. The purpose of preserving a life is not to freeze it. It is to keep its history available while allowing the person to continue into a future that has not yet been written.

If there is a reckoning, let it begin with attention. Let it begin with the willingness to read what is actually there. Let it begin with the refusal to treat a person as less than human because their story is difficult, their language is forceful or their circumstances are complicated. Let the same standard apply to everyone in the record.

I was trying to save the same humanity who, in my experience, forsook me. I cannot make that contradiction disappear. I can place it on the page and ask what it reveals about the world we have built, the systems we defend and the care we owe one another.

The record stays free. The life continues.

INTERLUDE I

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A LIFE AND ITS DESCRIPTION

A description is useful because it makes something manageable. It selects a few features and gives them names. Without descriptions, we would struggle to communicate. But a description becomes dangerous when it is mistaken for the whole person. A job title can tell us what someone did for a living. A diagnosis may describe a clinical assessment. A government category may determine eligibility for a service. None of these can tell us everything that matters about a human being.

The person described is always more extensive than the description. There are private memories, ordinary preferences, ambitions, relationships, disappointments, jokes, habits and hopes that may never appear in an official record. Some of these things may be irrelevant to a particular decision. They are not irrelevant to the person’s existence.

I have spent years moving between different descriptive systems. Art has its visual vocabulary. Journalism has its conventions. Advocacy has the language of rights and services. Academia has its methods and concepts. Government administration has its categories and procedures. Each system can illuminate part of a situation. Each can also make its own vocabulary seem more complete than it is.

The danger is especially pronounced when a description acquires authority. Once a phrase enters a file, it may be repeated by people who have not examined the original circumstances. A summary becomes the source for another summary. A provisional view can begin to look settled through repetition. The person may find that the words used about him travel further than his own explanation.

The answer is not to reject all description. It is to keep descriptions accountable to their sources and purposes. Who wrote the phrase? What information did they have? Was it a direct observation, a report from someone else, an opinion or a conclusion? Was the person given an opportunity to respond? Has the information been updated? These questions are not obstacles to understanding. They are how understanding becomes responsible.

I want this novel to resist the reduction of a life to a label while also resisting the opposite mistake of treating every self-description as beyond examination. The person deserves recognition. The account deserves scrutiny. Those commitments can coexist.

INTERLUDE II

WHAT A DOCUMENT CAN SAY

A document speaks in a particular voice. Sometimes that voice is formal and impersonal. Sometimes it is urgent, emotional or defensive. Sometimes it is a record of a decision; sometimes it is a request for one. Reading a document responsibly begins by asking what kind of document it is.

A letter can establish that a person wrote to an organisation on a particular date, provided the provenance is reliable. It may establish the words used in the request. It does not necessarily establish that the claims in the letter were true. A response can establish what the organisation said or decided. It does not automatically prove that the decision was correct or that every fact considered was complete.

A decision notice may have a specific legal effect. Its significance depends on the legislation, the decision-maker's authority, the reasons and any available review process. A notice that a matter was not allocated is not equivalent to a determination on the merits. A referral is not an endorsement. An acknowledgement is not a finding. These distinctions should be visible in any serious chronology.

The same care applies to personal records. A diary entry may be contemporaneous and valuable, but it remains the writer's account. A later recollection may contain important detail, but memory can change with time. A transcript depends on the recording, transcription method and context. A screenshot may show what appeared on a screen, but may omit surrounding information. No format is automatically complete.

When documents disagree, the disagreement should be preserved. It may result from a typographical error, a later amendment, a different version, a mistaken recollection or a substantive contradiction. The researcher's task is to investigate, not to choose whichever version best supports a preferred narrative.

This method may seem slow. It is slower than declaring a conclusion. But the purpose of an archive is not to produce the quickest possible certainty. It is to preserve the material in a form that allows careful examination. The more serious the allegation, the more important the method becomes.

I have learned that the most powerful sentence in a documentary account may be a modest one: this document establishes that the communication was sent; it does not establish that the recipient accepted its contents. Such a sentence may appear cautious, but it protects the integrity of the record. It prevents the archive from claiming more than it knows.

INTERLUDE III

THE PUBLIC PROMISE OF HUMAN RIGHTS

Human rights language exists because power needs limits. It reminds governments, institutions and individuals that a person is not merely an object to be managed. Rights language can create standards, duties and avenues for review. It can also become distant from the ordinary experience of people who need those standards to make a practical difference.

A right written in a convention or policy does not automatically deliver itself. People need accessible information, clear procedures, accountable decision-makers and practical means of seeking assistance. A person who cannot communicate with an agency, obtain a document or attend a meeting may find that a formal right is difficult to exercise.

This gap between promise and access has been a recurring concern in my advocacy and in my own experience. It is not enough for an organisation to point to a policy if the person cannot identify who is responsible for acting on it. It is not enough to say that a complaint pathway exists if the pathway is inaccessible or its outcome is not explained. The practical experience matters.

At the same time, rights are not a guarantee that every request will be granted. Different rights can interact. Resources and statutory powers have limits. Decisions may involve competing interests. A credible rights-based approach explains the applicable standard, considers the evidence and gives reasons. It does not turn every disagreement into a breach, but it does not dismiss a concern merely because the organisation has a policy.

The language of dignity is more fundamental than the language of victory. A person can lose a review and still deserve to be treated respectfully. An agency can reject a complaint and still owe a clear explanation. A person can be wrong about a particular fact and still have a right to participate in decisions affecting their life.

I want human rights to be more than ceremonial language. I want them to be visible in how people are spoken to, how decisions are explained, how information is corrected and how practical needs are addressed. Their value is tested in the small encounters as much as in the grand declarations.

INTERLUDE IV

THE WORK OF KEEPING A NAME

A name can be a point of continuity. It appears on documents, publications, correspondence and records. It allows one part of a life to be connected with another. But a name can also become contested terrain. Other people may use it in ways the person does not recognise. Institutions may record variations. A public identity may become more visible than the private person who carries it.

I have used the name Dr Barran Dodger as a public literary identity. It is associated with a body of work that crosses genres and purposes. The name does not replace Richard William McLean. It is a way of presenting and organising creative, academic and documentary work. The relationship between the names should be clear to readers, particularly when they are navigating official documents and public publications.

The title Dr has a formal academic basis in my doctoral qualification. It should be used accurately and not as a claim to expertise in every field discussed in my writing. Credentials describe a particular achievement. They do not make every opinion an academic conclusion. The same principle applies to professional histories: roles and registrations should be described within their actual scope and dates.

There is dignity in getting these details right. It is not necessary to embellish a biography. A truthful account of a person’s work is more compelling than a list of inflated claims. It allows readers to understand the actual development of a life and the different kinds of contribution made along the way.

Keeping a name also means keeping the person attached to it. The name should not become a demand that the person remain publicly available at all times. There must be room for silence, privacy and change. A life is not obliged to produce a statement every time something happens.

I want the name to carry the work, not consume the person. That is another form of preservation: not only preserving the documents, but preserving the possibility that the person who made them can continue to grow.